

1888 Kaiser Wilhelm II succeeds to the throne, with aspirations for German world role. Bismarck dismissed.

1898, 1900 Two German naval laws confirm the growth of the German navy as a rival to Britain's Royal Navy.

1905–06 German colonial claims in Morocco lead to tension with France and the UK. A second crisis in 1911, when Germany sends a gunboat to Agadir, is resolved in France's favor.

1914 Germany enters World War I on the side of Austria–Hungary and Ottoman Turkey as one of the Central Powers, fighting against the Allied Powers of the UK, France, Italy, Russia, Serbia, and Japan. Hopes for a quick victory on the Western Front are not fulfilled when Germany is obliged to retreat after the first Battle of the Marne in September 1914 and troops become bogged down in trench warfare along the Western Front with great loss of life. In April 1917 the US joins the war on the Allied side. There is greater success for Germany in the east where defeats for Russia precipitate two revolutions after which the new Bolshevik government withdraws from the war and accepts the degrading Peace of Brest-Litovsk in March 1918, surrendering much land.

1918 Despite now being able to concentrate its forces on the Western Front after the defeat of Russia, Germany is beaten back and forced to concede defeat in an armistice signed on November 11, 1918, after 1,774,000 German soldiers' lives have been lost. Facing a mutiny by military and naval forces and popular disillusionment with the war, Kaiser Wilhelm II's abdication is announced on November 9 and he flees into exile in Holland. Later that day a republic is proclaimed in Berlin with a government headed by Friedrich Ebert, the leader of the German Social Democratic Party.



U-boats surrender, 1918

Here, German U-boats are impounded by the Allies at the end of World War I. Germany fought an effective U-boat campaign, sinking 50 British cruisers in the first 10 weeks of the war.

1919 Ebert crushes a "Spartakist" revolt in Berlin, led by the German Communist Party (KPD) founded by Karl Liebknecht and Rosa Luxemburg in January 1919. Ebert is elected president and the constitution of a liberal democratic Weimar Republic is approved later in the same year.

1919 By the Treaty of Versailles Germany agrees to cede territory to France, Belgium, Denmark, and the new states of Poland, Czechoslovakia, and Lithuania. It is forbidden Anschluss, or union, with Austria, and loses all its colonies to League of Nation mandates. The Saarland is placed under the League of Nations, demilitarized, and occupied by Allied troops for 15 years. Germany is forced to accept its guilt in causing the war, pay financial reparations to the Allies, and limit the size of its armed forces.

1923 In retaliation for Germany's non-payment of reparations, French and Belgian troops occupy the Ruhr, withdrawing in 1924 after Germany accepts the Dawes Plan on reparations.

1923 Adolf Hitler, leader of the nationalist, anti-Semitic National Socialist German Workers' Party (NSDAP, or Nazis) stages an abortive putsch in Munich, as hyperinflation rages. He is imprisoned for eight months in 1924, during which time he writes *Mein Kampf* ("My Struggle").

1925 Field Marshal Paul von Hindenburg becomes president, ushering in a period of somewhat greater political stability. The arts flourish in Berlin, and Germany is admitted to the League of Nations in 1926 (of which it remains a member until Hitler's withdrawal in October 1933). However, the Weimar Republic proves too weak to weather the global economic recession that hits Germany after 1929 and soon causes mass unemployment.

1930 In the general election, support for the NSDAP increases sevenfold (to 18.3 percent) compared with the last election two years earlier.

1932 In a general election in July, the NSDAP wins 37.4 percent of the vote and replaces the SPD as the largest single party, although in a further election in November, its share of the vote falls to 33.2 percent. The Reichstag (parliament) finds itself increasingly unable to retain control of the situation as street violence escalates and Nazi supporters clash with their communist, socialist, and trade union opponents.

1933 President Hindenburg appoints Hitler chancellor at the head of a minority government in January. In March, after blaming the communists for an arson attack on the Reichstag, Hitler secures passage of an Enabling Act granting him dictatorial powers for four years. In July, Germany becomes a one-party state.

1934 In the "Night of the Long Knives," Nazis kill thousands of opponents within and outside the party. When Hindenburg dies in August 1934 Hitler assumes the presidency, although retaining the title "Führer" (leader).



Badge of rank

This Nazi Party badge with golden oak leaves was worn by high-ranking members only, many of them answerable solely to Hitler. By making himself the final arbiter between competing subordinates, Hitler increased his power.

1935 Nuremberg Laws strip Jews of their German citizenship and forbid marriages between Jews and German citizens. Jews are also removed from the armed services, the civil service, and, in 1938, all Jewish businesses are "Aryanized"—that is, transferred to "German" ownership with minimal compensation paid.

1935 The Saar, under League of Nations control since the end of World War I, again becomes part of Germany after a plebiscite shows overwhelming support for reintegration. In March of the following year, in violation of the 1919 Treaty of Versailles, German troops reoccupy the demilitarized Rhineland.

1936 The Olympic Games are held in Berlin and used to showcase Nazi ideals and propaganda.

1938 In the Anschluss, German troops enter Austria and incorporate it into the Third Reich. At the Munich conference in September, UK and France agree to Hitler's occupation of the Sudetenland border region in Czechoslovakia. By March 1939 all of Czechoslovakia is under Nazi control, with Slovakia becoming a puppet state.

1938 Jewish homes, businesses, and synagogues are attacked throughout Germany in the "Kristallnacht" (night of broken glass) pogrom.

1939 Germany seizes Memel from Lithuania.

1939 After secretly signing the Molotov–Ribbentrop nonaggression pact with the USSR on August 23, Germany invades Poland on September 1. Britain and France, treaty-bound to defend Poland, declare war on Germany on September 3, thus beginning World War II.

1940 Successful "Blitzkrieg" invasions of Norway, Denmark, Holland, France, and Belgium by June 1940 see Germany occupying most of Western Europe.

1941 Hitler opens a new eastern front, first invading Yugoslavia and Greece in April and then in June launching an offensive against the USSR. By the end of the year Leningrad is under siege and German forces are just miles from Moscow.

1942–43 In North Africa, the army of Field Marshal Erwin Rommel is gradually beaten back during 1942 and defeated at El Alamein in October. On the eastern front 300,000 German soldiers die defending Stalingrad and Field Marshal Paulus is forced to surrender in February 1943. Although Hitler

does not immediately appreciate the significance of the Japanese attack on Pearl Harbor in December 1941 which brings the US into the war, the addition of US forces on the Allied side eventually turns the tide in the Allies' favor.

1943 British and US air forces launch raids on German cities and industries.

1944 D-Day: Allied forces land in Normandy, France, in June, liberating Paris in August, Brussels in September, and crossing the Rhine in March 1945, while in the East, Soviet forces advance through Eastern Europe toward Berlin.

1945 Faced with military defeat on both the eastern and western fronts, Hitler commits suicide in his Berlin bunker on April 30. Two days later, Berlin falls to Soviet forces. On May 7 the German army capitulates to the Allies.

1945 The Allied Control Commission assumes control of Germany, which is divided into four (British, French, Soviet, and US) occupation zones, with four-power control over Berlin. Germany loses part of East Prussia to the USSR, and the rest of East Prussia and large parts of eastern Germany to Poland. In all, 3,250,000 German soldiers and 500,000 German civilians have died during World War II. Around 6,000,000 Jews (half of whom died at the Auschwitz–Birkenau concentration camp in Poland) have been massacred during the Holocaust. In November, trials of Nazi war criminals commence at Nuremberg.

1948–49 As Cold War tensions rise, a Soviet attempt to blockade West Berlin leads to a massive Allied airlift that keeps the city alive until the blockade is lifted. Berlin remains a source of tension between the two sides.

1948 A constituent assembly meeting in Bonn drafts the Basic Law for the three



Konrad Adenauer

Having been dismissed from office and imprisoned by the Nazis, Konrad Adenauer (1876–1967) was an ideal candidate for chancellor of West Germany in 1949. He integrated the nation into Western Europe and cultivated a friendship with France.